

service just ended up solving a lot of issues, including the ones mentioned above. All at one go!

So, now that we've understood the target audience for this sort of service, let's get started, shall we?

On your marks

Well, to begin with, it's a Web-based service! The good thing is you can use your OpenID (or even Gmail and Yahoo! IDs) to sign in. It doesn't force you to sign up for a Novell account. The bad news is that the service is by invitation only, for now. Remember when Gmail was launched in 2004? Send them a request, and keep your fingers crossed—although the report is that most get to create an account within a week.

You'll start off with a base template. The service provides three distros as options for a base OS—openSUSE 11.1, SUSE Linux Enterprise (SLE) 10 and SLE 11. Each of these distros have six templates to choose from:

1. JeOS (Just-enough OS) – Well, as the name suggests, it's just enough to be called an OS, suitable for minimalistic appliances.
2. Server – A text-only base
3. Minimal X – X Server + IceWM
4. GNOME desktop – base system + GNOME
5. KDE4 desktop – base system + KDE4
6. KDE3 desktop – base system + KDE3

After this, you'll have to make a decision between 32- and 64-bit architectures.

I'll take the example of the KDE4 distro we're bundling with LFY this month, to run you through the process. I selected openSUSE 11.1, KDE4 desktop and the 32-bit architecture. Now give a name to your appliance—mine's KDE 4.3 Live CD.

It's time to put on your editor's hat, because you now enter the wizard to start customising your distro/appliance. Click on the **Software** tab on the Web page. This is where you'll do most of your work. This section is divided into three: **Software sources**, **Selected software** and **Search for software**. See Figure 1 for the complete picture.

Under **Sources**, only openSUSE 11.1 and **Updates** repos are available, to start off with. The **Selected software** shows the software that's included, by default, based on the template you've started off with, and the **Search** section is where you're to locate what all is available in the repos. It is all interactive. One good thing is that when you enter a search term (by package name or pattern) it lists what's available, ranked by popularity. It lists the name of the application, its version, repository in which it is available, installed (not the download) size, and an action button to add (or remove already selected) applications.

Your first job is to identify what exactly you want. My job was to create 'The Perfect Desktop'. For that I needed the recently-released KDE 4.3, the latest version of OpenOffice.org and Firefox, besides support for multimedia codes and certain forms of drivers, out-of-the-box.

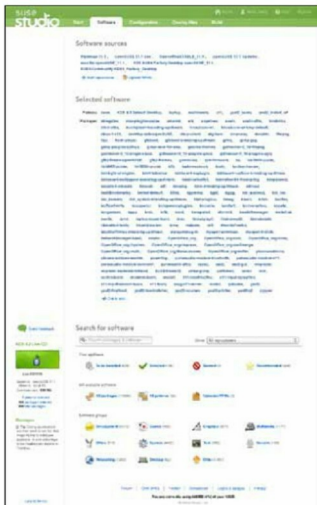


Figure 1: Under **Software** section we add applications we require

The default repositories offer older versions of all the essential applications, and the codes are plain missing in them.

Go to the **Software sources** section and click on 'Add repositories' (Figure 2). Here, you can either search for a repository if you know its name or search for a package and see which repository makes more sense to add, based on the popularity ratings and number of packages available. For example, a search for KDE 4.3 pops out two results, out of which the Build Service-based 'KDE:KDE4:Factory:Desktop openSUSE_11.1' made more sense. Likewise, I added the OpenOffice.org and Firefox repos that had the latest versions of these apps; and of course, Packman, essentially for codecs.

After adding them, it's time to go back to the software overview section again. If you want to add your own custom RPM (or something that's third party), there's an option to upload that as well—refer to the 'Upload RPMs...' link in Figure 1.

The good thing about openSUSE is the availability of software patterns (similar to meta packages offered by other distros) that can help you install a set of programs together instead of individual apps one by one—thus